

Episode 193: Summer Vacation 2012

When this manuscript is updated, it's probably around when everyone's Obon vacation is ending. Those who returned to their hometowns and such - man, good work! After the break, it's finally the feeling of this year's second half, right?

Continuing from last week, this week is also a summer vacation special. "*Mawaru Penguin* Colour Design Notes" is taking a break (laugh).

Now then.

Do you know the Former Iwasaki Residence in Tokyo's Ueno?

It's a historical building constructed in the late Meiji period as the main residence of the Iwasaki family, founders of "Mitsubishi." Consisting of Western and Japanese buildings, the Western building was used as the Iwasaki family's guest house, while the Japanese building was used for daily life. And this Former Iwasaki Residence has actually been used extensively in numerous manga and anime works as a model for so-called "Western mansions," and it appears prominently in a certain new TV series I'm participating in that's scheduled to start broadcasting next year (laugh).

I'd known about this Former Iwasaki Residence for quite a while, but while thinking I should go see it, I never quite had the opportunity. As always (and this time too) I'd received mountains of reference photos and was starting to feel like I understood it from looking at those, but no no, that's no good! No good! If the real thing can actually be seen, I really must see it properly. And if I actually go see it and experience that atmosphere, images related to it should expand tremendously!

So on a recent Sunday, I invited my wife and went to see it despite the heat.

3 minutes walk from Yushima subway station. In a corner surrounded by urban buildings, a space where trees grew densely suddenly appeared. That was the "Former

Iwasaki Residence Garden." Seeking the building, deeper and deeper into the cicada-singing forest. Walking along, suddenly a white Western building appeared right before my eyes! Since this is a "metropolitan park" managed by Tokyo, you pay admission at reception. Then entering the Western building through the main entrance. Oh, of course it's an important cultural property, of course shoes are forbidden. You put your shoes in a vinyl bag received at the entrance and carry it during the tour. Incidentally, photography was unfortunately prohibited inside the building (exterior photography is free).

Taking one step inside the Western building, man, it was magnificently another world! It's somehow frustratingly hard to express well, but you're overwhelmed by the minute, detailed decorative design. Not just saying "Rich!" but somehow the social status, the fundamental baseline of value is completely different dimension in everything. And while gorgeous, a gentle atmosphere. I time-tripped briefly, thinking of the gorgeous bygone era when this building was actually used.

Due to my profession, what concerned me was naturally "light" and "brightness (darkness)." Rather than placing lighting everywhere to make it brightly illuminated like modern Japanese buildings, the brightness creation relying on natural light caught my attention. Spatial expressions that change depending on how you take light, what kind of colour direction could show characters in such places, and so on. The colour design of individual decorations and overall room spaces was magnificent, but such colour design exists because of this harmony between natural light and artificial lighting - that kind of balance, I kept convincing myself (laugh).

Man, this kind of place has images that don't really expand from reference photos!

And the route went from Western to Japanese building. The connected Western and Japanese buildings completely changed atmosphere from their boundary and became Japan. It had such a "mansion" feeling that the word "mansion" seemed to exist for this place. Passing through such Japanese spatial feeling, the building tour ended. Going outside, there was a vast back garden. Originally it was a daimyo mansion garden in the

Edo period. The estate apparently became much smaller compared to those days, but no, it's still quite vast. The vast lawn surrounded by trees, when viewed from the Western building's second floor terrace, was truly a magnificent modern other world mixing Western and Japanese styles.

Man, wonderful. I could experience something wonderful. It was fun! Ah, I should have come earlier!

While thinking such things, savouring the feeling of wind passing through the lawn garden, my brief summer vacation ended (laugh).

When you're completely immersed in TV series schedules, honestly you can't take consolidated breaks whether it's Obon or whatever. Because there's broadcast every week, and you deliver one episode every week. Individual episode staff might be able to rest once they finish their assignments, but when you're at the centre of the production site and in a role where you must look at all episodes, it's quite impossible. Moving schedules forward so you can rest during Obon... such situations collapsed years ago in our anime industry (wry laugh). So last year and this year, my summer vacation and Obon break have been essentially zero.

So this kind of small mood change, new knowledge experience, is wonderful summer vacation that can soften my feelings.

Incidentally, admission is only 400 yen for adults! For just 400 yen you can have this experience! Everyone, if you're interested, please definitely go!

And you know, such "other worlds" still remain all over Tokyo. I'm filled with feelings of wanting to keep going out and standing in various places!

(12.08.21)

